

infrastructure are considered suitable for the cloud. Apart from these, there are applications that have an aspect of seasonality to them. There are certain points in time where the application infrastructure required has to be much larger and one needs to work out how to support those peak loads. There are event-based applications. Whether it is an SME or an enterprise, one has to first determine the application profile.”

Mehrotra suggests that one can decide on which applications are appropriate for the cloud in two ways. He said, “First is the load pattern of the application. If the infrastructure demand is very large for an application that’s being used, the in-house cost of it will be higher. If that cost will get reduced by using a cloud-based solution, and you are getting scalability by the service-provider—that is the cloud solution for you. One has to always make a load-analysis and understand the demand of the application.

“Yet another determinant of the profile has to be whether the application is core or non-core. If the applications are not core and their consumption is by only a small set of people rather than being used enterprise-wide, you can resort to the cloud. For example, if the procurement department in your organisation has 10 people working in it, you will not want to create a procurement platform for that small set of people. You may want to take a procurement application as a service from a cloud service provider. Similarly, consider a Contract Management System which is used by only a few people in the legal department, or a Risk Management System that is also used by a very few. These applications may be critical but since they are not served to a major proportion of the employees, they can be well served by the cloud.

“The third set of applications which can move to the cloud are the consumer-based applications, where there is no differentiation for the organisation. For example, with the email, it doesn’t matter whose email you are using, and whether it is based on internal or external infrastructure, as long as it can be made secure. For such applications, there is no distinction to your brand, to your buying process or to your selling process. These applications are best suited for the cloud. Whereas when it comes to core applications like an ERP, we do not see very large usage of such applications on the cloud. A Risk Management System or a Contract Management System is much more successful on the cloud as compared to an ERP.”

SLA commitments

Gaurav Agrawal, Sify Technologies Limited, says, “The Service Level Agreement is one of the key things that you have to look at. This is important because you are connected to an application on the Web. There is no infrastructure nearby. You will have to call the service desk of your cloud service provider to get the support. So you need a commitment from your service provider in the form of a SLA.”

Support

If you are migrating to the cloud for the first time, you have to understand how the migration of your applications will happen. You have to find out how much of the cloud offering can be configured to best suit your kind of set-up. This can either be through a cloud service provider or a channel partner, but configuration can play a prominent role in the business.

Security

This is one major fear when an organisation is migrating to cloud-based applications. It is not just about the security of the environment but the security involved in the processes that are being conducted in the cloud. You need to have access to these processes so that you can validate that the security environment is to the level your organisation is comfortable with, and you should be able to audit these using a third party. You should be able to visit a data centre and come back with the confidence that your information, data and your business processes are in a safe, secure and auditable position. For security audits, a majority of enterprises resort to third parties, while SMEs ask for third party certificates for security. You must also find out what kind of audit is allowed and what is not.

Degree of customisation

If you come across a cloud solution that requires too much of customisation, experts recommend that you do not adopt such a solution. All cloud applications provide a certain set of services and processes. The applications can be customised to a certain degree. But if your demand involves a high level of customisation and changes, cloud apps are not for you, because you are expecting that application to be changed to suit your business processes. This means that you are not ready to adopt the cloud yet. What you are looking for is someone to manage your apps environment in a ‘managed services’ way.

The ability of the cloud solution to interact with your existing apps

In today’s world, more and more applications are talking to each other. So, for example, if you have a portal or a workflow, it will be talking to your email system, OCR system or to some other application. If you go for a cloud-based application, you have to see whether those inter-connected needs of your system are being supported or served, and only if your service provider gives you the assurance of compatibility with your existing applications, can you go ahead with the solution. 

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